



What gives one human being the authority to decide the value of another?

Particularly when they have never met them.
Never sat with them.
Never heard their story.
Never witnessed their kindness.
Never seen the lives they have touched.
Yet somehow feel entitled to determine who they are.

This book began as a search for answers.
It became a search for dignity.
Because I came to realise that the greatest injury was not what people said about me.
It was allowing other people's judgments to become louder than my own voice.



ARTIST'S NOTE

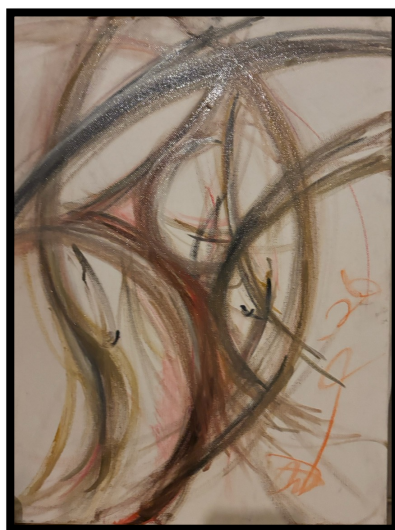
A personal account of loss, survival and the search for dignity.
The story behind the silence.
Reclaiming my name.

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The figures depicted are not illustrations of specific events, but emotional responses to lived experience. They represent states of being rather than individuals, and are intended to communicate aspects of grief, shame, endurance, isolation and resilience that often exist beyond the limits of language.

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LOSS OF DIGNITY



Introduction

This presentation is not an appeal.

It is not a defence.

A defence, as I experienced it, was never heard.

I never had the opportunity to speak directly in my own defence. I never had the opportunity to place my account before those whose decisions would alter the course of my life. Evidence which I believed supported my position failed to change the outcome, and years later I remain with the enduring sense that important aspects of my account were never fully considered.

Others may remember the process differently.

This is not their story.

It is mine.

What remains open is the human story.

The story of what happened afterwards.

The story of what it means to lose a profession, a livelihood, financial security, a sense of identity and, at times, hope itself.

For many years I worked as a psychotherapist. It was more than a profession; it was a vocation. I dedicated a significant part of my life to supporting others through suffering, trauma, loss and change. I believed deeply in the values of compassion, accountability and human dignity. Several years ago, a professional complaint led to disciplinary proceedings that ultimately resulted in the loss of my professional registration.

The official record documents the complaint, the findings and the outcome.

What it does not document is the human cost.



It does not document the sleepless nights I still experience, the unopened letters, the court orders, the financial collapse, the bankruptcy, the housing insecurity (which is ongoing), the shame, the isolation, the loss of purpose, the suicide attempts – a life of no purpose, all the years spent trying to rebuild a life that no longer resembled the one I had worked so hard to create.

It does not document what it feels like to wake each day carrying the consequences of a decision long after the decision-makers themselves have moved on.

It does not document what it feels like to watch a career disappear, to lose professional identity, to become increasingly isolated, as the phone stops ringing and those you thought would care disappear, and to find yourself struggling not only for financial survival but for emotional survival as well. To become defined by a bias finding rather than by my lifetime work. Not being able to get accommodation as prospectus landlords would google your name. To hate your very name so much it on its own had become my daily shame. Another shame I had to explain.

There came a point when the weight of that struggle became almost unbearable.

The tribunal took away my registration.

The years that followed very nearly took away my life. With repeated in-patient hospital care because society believed I should be kept alive, when I no longer wanted to feel this pain.



This pain that the very community I believed so strongly in wanted me dead.

Yet this presentation is not ultimately about defeat.

It is about survival.

The paintings and words contained within these pages were created during the years that followed. They are not evidence. They are not legal argument. They are not an attempt to persuade.

They are testimony.

They are a record of grief, shame, uncertainty, endurance and survival.

The figures depicted are not portraits.

They are emotional states.

They speak of the burden of judgment, the retreat into silence and the struggle to retain dignity when almost everything else has been lost.

Most of all, they are an invitation to consider the human being behind the file, the finding and the sanction.

Behind every regulatory decision is a life.

- Errol Hendrickse